Katrin Rohrbacher

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Research Areas

Modern German-Language Literature and Literary History, Narrative Theory, Environmental Humanities, Computational Literary Studies, Natural Language Processing, Artificial Intelligence and Large Language Models, Digital Humanities Infrastructure

Research Positions

03/2025–	**Research Associate (Postdoc)**, Text and Language Lab (Prof. Michaela Mahlberg), Department of Digital Humanities and Social Studies, Friedrich-Alexander-Universität Erlangen-Nürnberg
2021–2022	**Researcher and Project Manager**, PIVOT (PI: Prof. Dror Etzion), McGill University. Interdisciplinary action research project (narratology, psychology, sustainability research)
11/2015–02/2018	**Student Research Assistant**, Institute for Corpus Linguistics and Text Technology (ICLTT), Austrian Academy of Sciences. Text recognition and digital processing of Thomas Bernhard's literary estate (print and manuscript material)

Education

2018–02/2025	**PhD**, German Studies, Department of Languages, Literatures, and Cultures, McGill University Dissertation: *Aspects of Space: Quantitative Approaches to Fictional Worlds* Supervisor: Prof. Andrew Piper
2014–2018	**MA**, Department of Comparative Literature, University of Vienna Thesis: *The Works of Helga Michie in the Context of Exile in England* (*Die Arbeiten Helga Michies im Kontext des englischen Exils*) Supervisor: Prof. Christine Ivanović
2010–2014	**BA**, Department of Comparative Literature, University of Vienna

Publications

Doctoral Dissertation

Rohrbacher, K. (2025). *Aspects of Space: Quantitative Approaches to Fictional Worlds*. Doctoral dissertation, McGill University. eScholarship@McGill.

Journal and Conference Publications (peer-reviewed)

Rohrbacher, K., Reincke, J. & Mahlberg, M. (2027). Modeling Embodiment in Narrative Fiction. *Conference on Computational Humanities Research (CHR) 2027*. Accepted.

Rohrbacher, K. (2027). Auf den Spuren des Chronotopos: Genre und räumlicher Ausdruck in Märchen-, Kriminal- und Abenteuerliteratur. *DHd 2027*. Accepted.

Rohrbacher, K., Nieth, B., Salin, E., Eskofier, B. & Mahlberg, M. (2026). How LLMs Build Fictional Worlds: Setting and Narrative Space in AI-Generated Creative Storytelling. *Proceedings of the 2026 Conference on Empirical Methods in Natural Language Processing (EMNLP)*, pp. 41362–41384. Budapest, Hungary: Association for Computational Linguistics. https://aclanthology.org/2026.emnlp-main.1815/

Rohrbacher, K. & Schrittesser, D. (2026). Bridging the Gaps: Integrating Bibliographic Metadata into Wikidata for Literary Corpora. *Journal of Open Humanities Data*, 12(1), 37. https://doi.org/10.5334/johd.483

Rohrbacher, K. (2026). "Lived Space": A Computational Study of Setting in Fiction. In B. Herrmann, G. Grisot & R. Aust (eds.), *Comparing Landscapes: Approaches to Space and Affect in Literary Fiction*. Bielefeld University Press. Forthcoming (accepted).

Rohrbacher, K., Wagner, A. & Mahlberg, M. (2026). "Letting the Cat out of the Bag": Towards the Automatic Detection of Animal Metaphors in Literary Texts. *Book of Abstracts of DH2026*, ADHO Annual Conference, South Korea/hybrid, pp. 685–688. https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.21495909

Rohrbacher, K. (2025). de-Corp: A Corpus of German-language Fiction and Non-Fiction (1780–1930). *Journal of Open Humanities Data*, 11(1), 51. https://doi.org/10.5334/johd.350

Rohrbacher, K. (2025). Opening Worlds: Narrative Beginnings and the Role of Setting. *CCLS2025 Conference Preprints*, 4(1). Peer-reviewed and accepted for the 4th Annual Conference on Computational Literary Studies, Kraków 2025. Extended version in revision for the *Journal of Computational Literary Studies*. https://doi.org/10.26083/tuprints-00030149

Luederitz, C., Animesh, A., **Rohrbacher, K.**, Li, T., Piper, A., Potvin, C. & Etzion, D. (2023). Non-monetary narratives motivate businesses to engage with climate change. *Sustainability Science*, 18(6), 2649–2660. https://doi.org/10.1007/s11625-023-01386-1

Book Chapters and Reference Works (peer-reviewed)

Mahlberg, M. & **Rohrbacher, K.** (2026). Corpora in Digital Humanities and Corpus Linguistics. In H. Nesi & P. Milin (eds.), *International Encyclopedia of Language and Linguistics* (3rd ed., pp. 62–68). Elsevier. https://doi.org/10.1016/B978-0-323-95504-1.01548-9

Manuscripts in Preparation (invited contributions)

Mahlberg, M. & **Rohrbacher, K.** (in preparation). [Title to be confirmed]. In *The Oxford Handbook of Language and Masculinities*. Invited contribution, under contract.

Mahlberg, M. & **Rohrbacher, K.** (in preparation). Textual Patterns of Embodiment and World-building in Crime Fiction. In *Handbook of Language and Crime*. Bloomsbury. Invited contribution.

Funding and Fellowships Awarded

Period	Funding	Amount
08/2026–08/2027	**FAU Emerging Talents Initiative (ETI)**, "Nature in Motion: A Computational Study of Travelogues" (applicant, awarded).	CAD 22,050*
2026	**Travel Grant**, Office for Gender and Diversity, FAU Erlangen-Nürnberg (awarded)	CAD 735*
01/2021–02/2022	**Graduate Fellowship**, Wolfe Chair for Science and Technology, McGill University	CAD 7,500
	Total funding acquired	**CAD 30,285**

*converted from €15,000 and €500

Honors and Awards

12/2021	**Hans Walter Frischkopf Award** for Excellence in Teaching, McGill University
01/2020	**Graduate Excellence Award**, McGill University
01/2019	**Graduate Excellence Award**, McGill University

Research Data, Software and Resources

2026	**Reproducible pipeline for importing literary metadata into Wikidata** (with D. Schrittesser). Documented in https://doi.org/10.5334/johd.483
2026	**Classifier for the automatic detection of animal metaphors** (English). https://huggingface.co/katrohrb/animal-metaphor-classifier
2025–2026	**Transformer classifiers for the detection of spatial and setting categories** (German and English), with annotation guidelines. https://huggingface.co/katrohrb/de-setting-classifier, https://huggingface.co/katrohrb/narrative-space-classifier
2025	**de-Corp**, German-language literary corpus (1780–1930). https://zenodo.org/records/15714828; documented in https://doi.org/10.5334/johd.350

Academic Service

since 09/2026	**Representative** of the mid-level academic staff (PhD students and PostDocs), Department of Digital Humanities and Social Studies, FAU Erlangen-Nuremberg
04/2025–09/2026	**Deputy Representative** of the mid-level academic staff, Department of Digital Humanities and Social Studies, FAU Erlangen-Nuremberg

Conference and Workshop Organization

09/2025	**Co-Organizer**, DHSS Summer School "Data, Gender, and Society", FAU Erlangen-Nuremberg
01/2022	**Co-Organizer**, "7th Annual German Teaching Workshop", McGill University
03/2021	**Co-Organizer**, Graduate Research Conference, "Environment: Last Call", McGill University

Editorial Work, Peer Review and Memberships

2023–2025	**Managing Editor**, Journal of Cultural Analytics, https://culturalanalytics.org
2018–2022	**Editorial Assistant**, Journal of Cultural Analytics **Peer review**, Digital Humanities im deutschsprachigen Raum, Conference on Computational Humanities Research, Journal of Computational Literary Studies **Memberships**, ADHO, COMPTEXT, ACL

Teaching

Friedrich-Alexander-Universität Erlangen-Nürnberg, Department of Digital Humanities and Social Studies

Summer 2026	**DH 1: Sprache und Text** (Digital Humanities 1: Language and Text). Seminar with lab component
Summer 2026	**Critical AI**. Seminar
Winter 2025/26	**Computational Approaches to Storytelling**. Seminar

McGill University, Montreal, Department of Languages, Literatures and Cultures

Winter 2024	**Modern Short Fiction**. Seminar, taught in English
Winter 2023	**The German Novel**. Seminar, taught in English
2018–2024	**German as a Foreign Language**, beginner and intermediate level

Other Professional Experience

2017-2018	**Curatorial Assistant**, Halle für Kunst Steiermark, https://halle-fuer-kunst.at/

Invited Talks

12/2026	*Reading with Machines, Reading Machines: LLMs and Corpora in the Analysis of Literary Language*, University of Bamberg, English Linguistics Research Seminar
01/2026	*Measuring Narrative Space: A Computational Study of German and English Prose Fiction*, University of Bielefeld, Kolloquium Literaturwissenschaften Revisited
11/2025	*Aspects of Space: Quantitative Evidence and Fictional Worlds*, University of Hamburg, DH Lecture Series

Talks and Workshops (selected)

07/2026	**Talk**, ADHO Annual Conference 2026, South Korea, “Towards the Automatic Detection of Animal Metaphors in Literary Texts”
04/2026	**Talk**, 8th annual COMPTEXT conference, University of Birmingham, “Modeling Embodiment in Narratives”
09/2025	**Workshop**, FAU-Erlangen Nuremberg, DHSS Summer School, "Who is Doing What to Whom: Analyzing Gender Biases in Large Language Models"
07/2025	**Talk**, Conference of Computational Literary Studies, University of Krakow, “Opening Worlds: Narrative Beginnings and the role of Setting”
03/2025	**Talk**, Research Colloquium, Department of Digital Humanities and Social Studies, FAU Erlangen-Nürnberg, “Computational Modeling of Narrative Setting”
03/2024	**Talk**, ACLA Montreal, “Questions of Authorship and Agency in the Age of Machine Learning”

Supervision

since 11/2026	**Supervision** of a student research assistant in corpus construction and annotation (ETI project “Nature in Motion”), FAU Erlangen-Nuremberg
since 09/2025	**Supervision** of a student research assistant, Text and Language Lab, FAU Erlangen-Nuremberg. Statistical analysis and corpus construction
06/2025-06/2026	**Co-adviser**, MA-thesis, Marius Lin, "Framing of Political Discourse in Online Forums", FAU Erlangen-Nuremberg
03/2025-03/2026	**Co-adviser**, MA-thesis, Jan-Oliver Reincke, "Climate Change Narratives in Video Game Storytelling: A Text-Based Computational Study of Emotion", FAU Erlangen-Nuremberg

Additional Training

ongoing	**FAUnext**, career programme for postdoctoral researchers, FAU Erlangen-Nürnberg

Methods and Technical Skills

Computational analysis, Python, NLP and machine learning, large language models
Corpus and data work, corpus construction and curation, annotation guidelines, text recognition (print and manuscript)
Research infrastructure, Linked Open Data (Wikidata, Wikibase), reproducible pipelines, open-source tool development

Language Skills

German (native), English (fluent), French (intermediate)